



BEFORE

After the near defeat at Stones River (see [The Battle of Stones River](#)), Rosecrans spent the spring and early summer of 1863 rebuilding his strength, much to Lincoln's exasperation.

THE TULLAHOMA CAMPAIGN

When Rosecrans finally moved in late June and early July, he succeeded in **driving Bragg out of south-central Tennessee**, leaving the major railroad junction of Chattanooga **vulnerable to capture**.

In one week, Union troops **pushed their foes back almost 80 miles** (129km) at the cost of only 570 casualties—an advance known as the Tullahoma Campaign. But then **Rosecrans stalled**, waiting for repairs to railroads and more supplies, before he moved forward again.

Reactivated to command the Army of the Ohio, General Ambrose Burnside marched on Knoxville, the “capital” of East Tennessee. On September 3, 1863, he was greeted with joy by most of its citizens, who were Union sympathizers. Meanwhile, Rosecrans had been on the move since mid-August, advancing virtually unopposed the last few miles to Chattanooga, thanks to various feints and deceptions that fooled General Braxton Bragg about his final objective.

On September 8, the Confederates evacuated Chattanooga, to the great dismay of Jefferson Davis, who wrote, “We are now in the darkest hour of our political existence.” But Davis had weathered similar military disappointments before and was determined to turn this one around. Bragg withdrew to northern Georgia, where he received two divisions from Joseph E. Johnston’s inactive army, bringing the strength of the Army of Tennessee almost on par with Rosecrans’s force. To provide Bragg with the numerical superiority that might bring victory, Davis also sent him the bulk of Longstreet’s corps from the Army of Northern Virginia. Lee protested, claiming that he needed Longstreet and his divisions for a new offensive against General Meade, but Davis rightly understood that the decisive theater of war was, for now, in the West.

Tension mounts

On September 9, the first of Longstreet’s seasoned troops boarded trains for a 550-mile (885-km) journey through Virginia, Carolina, and Georgia. The direct route from Virginia to Tennessee no longer